MASTERING LINE GRAPHS · CHAPTER 2 CHEAT SHEET

Describing Trends

Choose the word the data supports: direction first, then size and speed.

Verbs by direction

UP	DOWN
rose, increased, grew, climbed	fell, decreased, declined, dropped
edged up (very small)	dipped (small and short)
surged, soared (large, fast)	plummeted (large, fast)

No change: remained stable, levelled off (after a rise or fall), plateaued, hovered around 40%.
Up and down: fluctuated, rose and fell. It is not an increase or a decrease.

Adverbs: size and speed

- **slightly**: a small change (50,000 to 51,000)
- **gradually, steadily**: slow and even over time. This is about speed, not size.
- **sharply**: fast and steep
- **significantly, considerably**: large
- **dramatically**: very large. Save it for the biggest change.

Calculate before you choose. 51,000 to 70,000 is about 37%. That is not slight.

Two sentence patterns

Verb + adverb
Passenger numbers rose sharply from 51,000 to 70,000 between March and April.

There was + adjective + noun
There was a sharp rise in passenger numbers, from 51,000 to 70,000.

Don't mix them: rose sharp, a sharply rise.

Time expressions

- **A point:** in 2010, at the start of the period
- **A period:** between 2010 and 2015, from 2010 to 2015, over the decade
- **Throughout:** throughout the period, in every year shown
- **An end point:** by 2015, by the end of the period

Keep the tone neutral

Some verbs carry a feeling. *Boomed* and *flourished* are positive; *slumped* and *spiralled* are negative. Use them only when the feeling matches the topic: sales boomed, never mortality boomed.

Neutral verbs are always safe: rose, fell, remained stable.

Common mistakes

- rised → **rose** (rise, rose, risen)
- surged steadily: a surge is sudden
- remained stably → remained **stable**
- declined of 21 points → declined **by** 21 points
- fluctuated for a line with one dip

Check before you write

1. Which way did the line move?
2. How big was the change? Calculate it.
3. How fast?
4. Does my word carry a feeling the data doesn't? Choose a neutral one.